

COURSE 4 OF 8

Color & Pigment Lab

Mix confident, repeatable color and pull off geode, ocean, and galaxy effects — without wasting a big pour on a guess.

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SECTION 1

Pigment Types: Mica Powder, Liquid Dye, and Alcohol Ink

By the end of this section you'll know which pigment to reach for and roughly how much to start with.

Almost every resin color effect is built from just three pigment families — the trick is knowing what each one is actually good at.



Step-by-Step: Testing a New Pigment

- 1 **Mix your resin and hardener completely first** — Combine Part A and Part B at the exact ratio and for the full time printed on your resin's label before adding any color. Tinting an incompletely mixed batch can leave soft or sticky spots that have nothing to do with the pigment.

- 2 **Add pigment in small amounts** — Start with a small pinch of mica powder or a few drops of dye/ink per small batch, stir thoroughly, and check the color against the light before adding more.
- 3 **Scale up only after a test** — Once a ratio looks right in a small cup, repeat the exact same proportions in your full batch rather than eyeballing a bigger pour.

Common Mistake

Adding too much pigment — mica powder, dye, or ink — can block the chemical reaction that cures resin, leaving a tacky or soft surface that never fully hardens. Stay under the maximum load your pigment's own label recommends; it varies by brand and pigment type.

PIGMENT TYPE	OPACITY	BEST FOR
Mica powder	Translucent to fully opaque, shimmery finish	Solid color layers, metallic edges, dusting for "stars" or shimmer
Liquid resin dye	Translucent, jewel-toned	Deep saturated color through a whole piece, like stained glass
Alcohol ink	Highly translucent, moves and "blooms" in wet resin	Small accent pieces, organic color blends — not full large-batch tinting

Do It This Way

Keep every pigment in a labeled, closed container away from direct sun — mica powder clumps with humidity, and both dye and alcohol ink can fade or shift color if left in a sunny window.

SECTION 2

Building a Color Swatch Card Before You Commit

By the end of this section you'll have a permanent, reusable reference for every color combination you mix.

A swatch card turns color choice from a guess into a lookup — five minutes of testing can save an entire large pour.



Step-by-Step

- 1 **Mix small test batches** — About 10 g (roughly 2 tsp) of mixed resin per sample is enough; test one pigment type and loading percentage per batch.

- 2 **Pour into a swatch mold or silicone mat** — Small round or square cavities work well, or simple blobs on a silicone mat if that's all you have.
- 3 **Label each sample while it's still wet** — Write the pigment name and amount used on a small card or sticky note next to each cavity; once cured, nearly identical colors are hard to tell apart from memory.
- 4 **Let every swatch cure the full listed time** — Resin color can shift slightly as it fully cures, so a touch-dry check isn't a true preview of the final shade.
- 5 **Compare under real lighting** — Hold swatches up against the surface or lighting your finished piece will actually live in before scaling a color up to a big pour.

Swatch Card Checklist

- ☐ Every sample is labeled with pigment name and amount, written before it cures
- ☐ Each swatch was left to cure the full time on the resin's label
- ☐ Swatches were compared under the lighting the final piece will be displayed in
- ☐ The card is stored somewhere you'll actually find it again (a binder or small box, not a loose pile)

SECTION 3

The Geode Effect

By the end of this section you'll be able to build a geode-style piece with a defined "crystal" cavity and metallic edge.

The geode effect is really three simple layers — a dark base, a light cavity, and a metallic vein — built in order.



Step-by-Step

- 1 **Pour and cure a dark base layer** — Black or deep-colored tinted resin, poured thin and cured, gives the piece depth and makes the lighter cavity pop by contrast.

- 2 **Mark out a free-form cavity shape** — On top of the cured base, build up an irregular, organic cavity area using white or very light tinted resin — avoid perfectly round or symmetrical shapes, which read as artificial.
- 3 **Add texture inside the cavity** — Crushed glass, clear resin "crystal" chips, or coarse glitter sold for geode work add dimension once set into the light layer while it's still workable.
- 4 **Define the vein** — Trace the border between the dark base and the light cavity with a fine metallic paint pen, or a small amount of metallic mica mixed into clear resin applied with a fine brush.

Do It This Way

Let each layer reach at least a firm, tacky set — not necessarily full cure — before adding the next one. Pouring a new layer onto fully liquid resin below it can cause the layers to blend instead of staying distinct.

SECTION 4

Ocean and Wave Effects

By the end of this section you'll be able to build a layered ocean piece with cell texture and a believable whitecap line.

Ocean effects rely on layering color by depth and using controlled heat to create the cell patterns that read as water movement.

Step-by-Step

- 1 Layer dark to light** — Pour your deepest blue or teal first, then progressively lighter blues and a translucent white toward the top edge, to mimic how real water looks deeper in the distance.
- 2 Tilt the surface while it's still wet** — Gently rocking the piece lets the colors flow into each other at the boundaries instead of sitting in flat, hard-edged bands.
- 3 Create cells with brief heat** — Pass a heat gun or butane torch quickly over the wet surface, holding it about 4-6 in (10-15 cm) away and keeping it constantly moving; this both pops surface air bubbles and pulls the colors into natural-looking cell patterns.
- 4 Pull a whitecap line** — Drag a toothpick or thin brush loaded with white pigment (a drop of isopropyl alcohol mixed in helps it spread) along the boundary between two color bands to suggest breaking foam.

Safety First

A heat gun or torch is a real fire and burn hazard around liquid resin and its fumes. Work in a ventilated space, keep flammable materials and loose hair or sleeves well clear, never leave the tool running unattended, and know where a fire extinguisher is before you start.

SECTION 5

Galaxy and Swirl Effects (Plus Troubleshooting)

By the end of this section you'll be able to pull off a galaxy-style swirl and fix the most common color mistakes before they ruin a piece.

Galaxy effects use the same dark-to-light layering logic as ocean pieces, but swirled instead of banded — and most "muddy color" problems come down to one habit.



Step-by-Step

- 1 **Pour a dark base** — Black, deep purple, or navy tinted resin as the foundation sets up the contrast the rest of the effect depends on.

- 2 **Add two or three translucent colors** — Drop small amounts of purple, blue, and pink (or your chosen palette) onto the base in an uneven, random pattern rather than evenly spaced dots.
- 3 **Swirl lightly with a toothpick or skewer** — A few gentle figure-eight passes are enough; stop as soon as you see distinct color ribbons.
- 4 **Dust on "stars" before it gels** — A light scatter of fine white or silver mica powder, or extra-fine glitter, while the surface is still wet gives a star-field effect once cured.

Common Mistake

Overmixing is the single biggest cause of a muddy, gray-brown swirl instead of distinct color bands — every extra pass blends the colors a little further toward each other. Stop swirling as soon as the pattern looks right, even if it feels like "not enough."

Troubleshooting Common Color Problems

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Muddy or murky color	Overmixing, or combining near-opposite colors that cancel each other out	Swirl less; test complementary color pairs on a swatch first
Pigment settling or sinking	Pigment heavier than the resin's viscosity, or poured and left to sit before use	Stir pigment back in right before pouring; use less per batch
Color fading over time	UV exposure, especially on resin or pigment without UV-resistant additives	Display out of direct sunlight; this isn't a defect in a single piece, it's a property of resin and pigment in general

Next Step

Your color toolkit is ready. Open **Jewelry & Accessories Line** next to put these effects to work on small molds — earrings, pendants, and rings — where a little color goes a long way.